

Sizing up soil

Different types of soil have different sized particles.



Sandy soils contain particles about 2 mm (0.08 in) across.



Clay soils have very small particles. Water collects between them.



Loamy soils have a mixture of small and large particles.



Soil erosion

When soil is farmed too much, its nutrients get used up. The topsoil blows or washes away. Not many plants can survive in these areas without the rich topsoil.

Ploughing helps keep soil fertile.



Ploughing breaks up soil to stop it getting hard and solid. This helps crops grow more easily.



Important earthworms

Earthworms help to make fertile soil. Their burrows let air into the soil, and create pathways for water to move around more easily. Earthworms also help the remains of plants and animals to decompose. This releases important nutrients into the soil. Earthworm waste is good for soil too!



Hands on

Half fill a jar with soil and top it up with water. Put on the lid and shake. Leave for a day. The soil should separate into layers.